

Lesson 2

How You're Making Your Nervous System Worse

I wanna tell you about the things that I did that I thought were helping, but were actually keeping my nervous system sensitized. These are things that you are most likely doing as well. Now, I was not doing anything wrong. I was terrified and my system was trying to protect me. The only way it knew how.

The problem though was that the ways that I was trying to help myself were teaching my nervous system the opposite of what I wanted it to learn. For years, I treated healing like it was my full-time job. I was researching for hours every single day. This felt like what adults are supposed to do when they have a problem.

Like obviously the answer to all of this was to find the correct thing so that the problem would go away, and then my fear would finally stop. But what I didn't understand at that point was that my nervous system was playing very close attention to how I was behaving. So every time I dove back into research, every time I picked up my phone to check something, every time I scrolled looking for answers, my nervous system was getting one message.

We are not safe yet. Increase the alarm. That would be in the form of sensations, thoughts, feelings, or symptoms. The more I searched, the more I wired that alarm. Looking back now, I can see that what I was doing fell into one of three categories, and I do not share these to make you feel bad. If you recognize yourself when I talk about them, I share them because I wish someone would've named them explicitly for me sooner.

The first one was looking for the singular person who could fix me. This is where we all start out. I went to a lot of doctors, a lot of specialists. I got an MRI tests, blood work, second opinions, third opinions, neurologists, pain specialists, naturopaths, anyone who might be able to finally tell me what the hell was wrong.

And then I got to the point where the medical side ran out of answers for me. So then I moved over to the mind body side. Coaches, programs, practitioners. I was looking for that one person who really understood this, the one who had the one singular method that would work. So there was always an appointment on my calendar.

There was someone I was planning to see. It was something I was always looking forward to because I thought this may be the thing, and there's nothing wrong with getting help, but there was a

specific energy that I was bringing to every appointment and every time I was seeking something out, it was that maybe this would be the person who would finally.

Fix me. Maybe this program would be the one singular thing. And then when it didn't work, I didn't pause and think about what could possibly be happening here. I just found the next thing. I was always on the hunt. And when you live in that way and your behavior looks like that. It does not create safety.

It creates urgency. And so what my nervous system learned was that we hadn't solved this problem yet, so we needed to keep searching for anyone who could. The second one was compulsive research and content consumption. I was absorbing everything. I'm not being sarcastic when I say that. I spent nine hours a day on my phone, reading books, audio books.

Listening to podcasts, watching YouTube videos, watching recovery stories, following every nervous system account I could find. I was in Facebook groups. I was reading other people's stories, whether they were success stories or horror stories, anything that might give me a clue about what was happening to me and whether or not I was actually gonna be okay.

And it did help. For a minute, I'd find something that made sense and would give me a little bit of relief, and then I'd need more. And more. My screen time was insane and I still was never getting to the point where I was getting any clear answers, and during that time, my nervous system wasn't learning that we're figuring it out or that we had figured it out.

It was learning. We are still looking, which must mean we are still in danger here. So information became my new coping mechanism. It was like a life vest for me, but it was not calming my system. It was keeping my attention locked on the problem. The third one is the reassurance trap. I was constantly checking, checking my body for symptoms, checking Google for explanations, checking Reddit, checking with other people.

Did this happen to you? Did you have this symptom? Did you struggle with this? Is this a mind body condition? I was comparing my timeline to other people's timelines. I was really looking for someone to tell me that I was going to be okay. What I was really doing here was trying to find a certainty, and that is the thing with certainty.

You can never get enough of it and it never does the trick. Every bit of reassurance that you get wears off, it feels like in less and less time. We're talking like two minutes before it's like, Nope, that wasn't it. That wasn't enough. It didn't scratch that itch. I need more. My nervous system learned that uncertainty was very, very dangerous.

I believed that I could not handle not knowing. And that continued to keep the alarm running. None of this was happening because I was just out of control and super dramatic. It was because my system was trained to treat any uncertainty as danger, and then I kept responding in ways that confirmed it. I did not understand that my nervous system was listening to what I was doing and how I was responding, not what I knew, not what I intellectually understood.

So every time I reacted, like something was very urgent, like I needed to get to the bottom of it, I needed to do a bit more research. I needed to check, I need to ask. It learns. And learns, and learns and rewires that we have a problem because what you react to in that way, you wire in. That is the pattern I was stuck in and I did not know there was another way.

This lesson isn't asking you to stop everything today. I'm not telling you, delete your apps. Cancel all your appointments, throw away your supplements, get rid of everything. I'm asking you to see very clearly what is actually feeding these symptoms and feeding this sensitization. This alarm, you need to notice and take accountability for the behaviors that feel like they're giving you safety, but are in reality, keeping your system stuck.

So if you recognize yourself in any of this, which you should at this point, this is, these are very common behaviors, so it wouldn't surprise me at all if you're like, Ooh, oopsies, I'm doing all of that. What's happening is you're just starting to see this pattern. Or on the flip side, maybe you are very well aware of this pattern.

Very likely the case, you know exactly what's happening, but you keep getting stuck in this loop because the loop feels like the safety. That's okay. It's very normal, but if you want this to change, you're going to have to start behaving in a new way because that is where the change begins. In the next lesson, we're gonna talk about the necessary shift that you must make in order for this to change.

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